REPORT ON PERMACULTURE DESIGNER COURSE (PDC) TRAINING WITH PERMACULTURE UGANDA, 2025

Permaculture Uganda

Permaculture Initiative Uganda is a non-profit organisation that aims to bring about peace via affordable permaculture education. It has a community capacity building farm based in Butambala, near Kampala. https://permacultureuganda.org/

Ngombor

Ngombor Community Development Alliance is a Community Based Organization based in Nebbi District of Uganda. Ngombor envisions a community with a resilient food production system and biodiversity, to achieve that Ngombor is working towards establishing a permaculture demonstration farm that will train the local community in permaculture practice.

We believe that Permaculture plays a vital role in agrifood systems by promoting sustainable food production through practices that mimic natural ecosystems, emphasizing biodiversity, soil health, water conservation, and minimizing reliance on external inputs like chemical fertilizers and pesticides, ultimately contributing to a more resilient and environmentally friendly food system.

Background

A Permaculture Design Course (PDC) is a 72-hour intensive certificate training program that teaches the principles and practices of permaculture design. It is an internationally recognized credential. Those who complete it are legally and internationally authorized to use the word permaculture for individual and commercial purposes. The course equips individuals with

the knowledge and skills to design sustainable systems that mimic natural ecosystems.

The course is the first and vital phase in beginning to understand the development and practicing of permaculture ethics, principles, design and implementation techniques. After fully completing the course, all the participants are recognized as permaculture graduates and therefore able to design and manage their own or community permaculture farm or could further apply for a Diploma in Applied Permaculture Design.

Participants from Ngombor

#	Name	Gender
1.	Lekuru Winny Hope	F
2.	Ulargiw K. Vincent	M

Objectives

The overall objective of the course is to enable participants learn about Permaculture, read and see it applied in a wide range of climates and

budgets, to develop observation skills, learn how nature responds to challenges and apply these ideas to human needs

Other objectives

- To equip the participants with knowledge and skills to design and implement a sustainable permaculture demonstration farm by introducing permaculture design principles and ethics
- To acquire knowledge and skills for training small holder farmers in the community on how to apply permaculture techniques and strategies in different climatic types
- To learn how to apply permaculture principles and ethics in various aspects of life for instance in food production, home design, and economic enhancement by understanding patterns in nature and utilizing them in design
- To equip the participants with the knowledge and skills that foster mindset of designing solutions that work in harmony with nature and address societal challenges by Planning for water management, soil health, and earthworks
- Be able to design social, legal, and economic aspects of human settlements in the surrounding community.

Methodology

The training was done through participatory classroom lecture and field practical in every stage of course for the 12 days.

Achievements

- We were able to acquire the capability to design resilient and flourishing ecosystems for both individual and professional applications which knowledge will be used to train the surrounding community.
- It was a good experience for us to enhance our knowledge on sustainable living practices, practical skills in regenerative design, and a deeper understanding of natural systems which knowledge will apply to our personal lives and will be used to change the mindset of the community we work with.
- The students were equipped with the knowledge and skills for solving social, community and global problems for such as social inequity, gender issues, soil infertility, climate change, water and food shortages.

- Acquired practical skills and knowledge of how to practice organic farming/gardening, proper soil management, how to catch and store water resources, how to manage and recycle wastes which are all elements of being self-reliant while putting nature in mind..
- We were able to learn how to reclaim degraded soil and restore its fertility for high yield crop production while minding about ecosystem.
- we did not have the opportunity to many people apart from the participants but i happened to get contact of Charles Mugarura who works with https://broadfieldpermaculture.org

Challenges

- Some content on the course outline was not covered
    - We covered most of the major components, however rammed earth construction and composed toilet construction which were not fully tackled.
- The training involved a lot of practical work which was more of demonstration and physical than theoretical
- Language barrier for some participants (though not for Ngombor participants). A lot of time was spent on translation so there was less time for theory
- Unavoidable circumstances like rainfall and community events sometimes interfered with the lessons and field work, especially as the classroom was also outside.

Recommendations

- There is need to do a lot of research & reading to get a deeper understanding of permaculture practices to add up on the basics learnt from the training

    - We have access to some free online training, but we will need to buy some books and exchange visit to other well established permaculture farms.

- For our next training we will scope out in more detail what the training curriculum and facilities will be. It will be useful to develop relationships and explore training with other Permaculture training organizations, such as the Permaculture Research Institute https://www.priug.org/meet-the-team or https://broadfieldpermaculture.org/contact/

- This training was useful, as our farm will also be in early stages of development, but it is important to visit a well established permaculture farm to deepen our knowledge.

- Put what was learnt during the training into practice by starting the process of establishment of the model farm. This will be done together with the group members.

Implementation plan/way forward

We have developed a design and implementation plan for the first phase of the permaculture model farm. Like any other permaculture farm, we will have 5 zones beginning with Zone 0 which comprises of residential buildings area and its surrounding. Zone 1 is the area of intense care crop that need frequent visits during the time of the day in our design, this zone will encircle zone 0 then Zone 2 is comprised of the food forest area followed by Zone 3 where cash crops is grown, Zone 4 will comprise of hood trees meant for mostly timber and construction purposes, it may also be used for grazing animals while Zone 5 is the wild/untamed area and in this farm it will be used for apiary project.

In this phase of implementation, we intend to start with Zone 0, 1 and 2 while next year in the first planting season the implementation will be extended to Zone 3 where as Zone 4 already has some teak trees, we only need to plant some more eucalyptus. In an effort to train the community (group) members on permaculture practices, they will be involved in all stages of implementation to enable them acquire permaculture knowledge and skills which they are expected to go and implement in their various individual homes, after which there will be follow up visits as part of mentorship program for the members.

At the moment we are working with only 1 group but in future we intend to form other groups that will be attending training at the farm in shifts during the week, for instance the current group meets on Wednesdays to carry out their group activities which include village savings, farm activities, meetings etc

Winny talking to the group members on group dynamics in one of the meetings, in the background in the group nursery bed for vegetables

Conclusion

The course was intensive and the participants were very excited about it. A heartfelt appreciation goes to the sponsor who sacrificed her time and resources to make it possible for us to attend, further appreciation goes to the trainer for offering his time to share his knowledge

Appendix: Further resources

Stories/Testimonials

Go to https://ngombor.org/stories to read personal stories about the impact the training had.

Photos and videos

Permaculture training photo album